Case Study: How Stepstone Uses n8n to Automate Business Operations

1. What problem/use case did Stepstone have?

Stepstone is one of Europe's largest online job platforms. It connects job seekers with companies looking to hire employees.

The company handles millions of job-related documents every month and has thousands of employees working across different departments.

Initially, Stepstone used manual processes for several repetitive business activities. As the company grew, these processes became time-consuming and difficult to manage.

The main problems were:

A. Repetitive manual tasks

- Employees had to perform repetitive activities such as processing contract mappings and updating contract records.
- These tasks consumed valuable working hours.
- Employees had less time to focus on important business activities.

B. Dependency on technical teams

- Non-technical employees depended on developers to access APIs and retrieve external data.
- Some teams had to wait weeks or months to get the required technical support.

C. Difficulty managing automation

- Stepstone initially used the free Community Edition of n8n.
- As usage increased, managing hundreds of workflows became difficult.
- Employees shared credentials, and workflow access permissions were difficult to manage.
- Monitoring workflow executions and protecting sensitive information became important concerns.

D. Lack of automation knowledge among employees

The company wanted employees outside the engineering team, such as marketing and customer service staff, to automate their own repetitive tasks.

However, they needed proper training and guidance to use automation effectively.

In short: Stepstone wanted to reduce manual work, improve operational efficiency, reduce dependency on developers, and make automation accessible to employees across the organization.

2. Where and why did they implement n8n?

Where did they implement n8n?

Stepstone implemented n8n across different business departments and internal operations.

Some important areas include:

- **Marketplace Management:** Handling job-related data and automating marketplace operations.
- **Customer Service:** Automating contract mapping and updating contract records.
- **Marketing:** Introducing automation to marketing employees through a pilot program.
- **IT Security:** Running a separate n8n instance to manage sensitive employee-related information.
- **Internal Business Operations:** Automating data retrieval, reporting, and repetitive processes.

Why did they implement n8n?

Stepstone initially introduced n8n in 2021 through an engineer named Luka Pilic.

The company selected n8n because it helped automate repetitive tasks and connect different systems without requiring employees to perform every operation manually.

The main reasons were:

1. **Reduce manual work:** Automate repetitive business processes and save employee time.
2. **Improve productivity:** Allow employees to focus on more important tasks.
3. **Connect different systems:** Integrate APIs, internal tools and external applications.
4. **Improve data processing:** Handle millions of job-related documents efficiently.

5. **Enable self-service automation:** Allow non-technical employees to create automation workflows.
6. **Improve security:** Enterprise features provide better credential management, access permissions and workflow monitoring.

Why did they upgrade to n8n Enterprise?

By early 2025, Stepstone had more than 700 active workflows.

The Community Edition was no longer sufficient for managing automation at this scale.

Therefore, they upgraded to n8n Enterprise to get:

- Role-based access control.
- Secure credential management.
- Single Sign-On (SSO) through Okta.
- Better execution monitoring.
- Version control.
- Separate environments for sensitive workflows.

In short: Stepstone implemented n8n across its business operations to automate repetitive tasks, connect systems and improve productivity. It upgraded to Enterprise to manage its growing automation infrastructure securely.

3. How was the workflow implemented?

Stepstone implemented n8n in two major ways: technical automation and AI-assisted employee onboarding.

A. Technical workflow implementation

Luka and his team created workflows that connected business systems and automated repetitive tasks.

A typical workflow follows this process:

Example of an n8n automation workflow

1. Data/Input

Receive information from internal systems, databases or external APIs

2. n8n Workflow

Trigger the workflow and process incoming information

3. Data Processing

Validate, filter, transform or update the required information

4. Output

Send the processed information to the appropriate business system

For example, when contract data arrives, an n8n workflow can process the information, identify the required changes and update the relevant records.

The exact nodes and technical configurations used in Stepstone's individual workflows are not disclosed in the case study. This diagram represents the general automation approach.

B. AI-powered chatbot implementation

Stepstone also developed an AI chatbot to help employees create automation ideas.

The chatbot was connected to:

- The n8n Chat interface.
- The n8n MCP server.
- Stepstone's internal MCP for Confluence and Jira.

How does it work?

1. An employee opens the chatbot.
2. The employee describes a business problem in simple language.
3. The chatbot asks questions to understand the requirements.
4. It checks whether the automation idea is technically possible.
5. It evaluates and scores the feasibility of the idea.
6. If the idea is feasible, it generates a workflow diagram and explains the implementation steps.

In the next development phase, Stepstone planned to use Claude AI with n8n MCP to help scaffold the actual workflow.

The purpose is to help employees understand automation rather than simply giving them a completed workflow without learning.

C. Employee training

Stepstone also introduced a structured training program.

The initial pilot involved approximately 10 marketing employees.

They receive training in:

- Data literacy.
- Automation fundamentals.
- Identifying repetitive tasks.
- Understanding how workflows operate.

This helps employees become confident in using n8n.

4. How did n8n help Stepstone in real-world scenarios?

This is one of the most important sections of your assignment because it demonstrates the actual business value of n8n.

Here are three examples from the case study.

Use case 1: Automating contract mapping

Daily batch reduced to ~20 seconds

Problem:

A large reseller changed its data feed structure, resulting in 60–70 contract mapping tasks arriving every day.

Customer service employees had to manually process each task, taking approximately 2–3 minutes per task.

How n8n helped:

Luka developed an n8n workflow to automate the contract mapping process.

Instead of manually processing every task, the workflow handled the repetitive work automatically.

Result:

- Previously: Approximately 2–3 hours of manual work daily.
- After automation: The entire daily batch takes around 20 seconds.

- Employees can focus on other important customer service activities.

Use case 2: Automating discontinued product removal

Significant employee time saved

Problem:

Stepstone discontinued a product, but references to that product remained in approximately 4,500 contract entries belonging to 20 major customers.

Employees needed to find and remove the discontinued product from the relevant records.

How n8n helped:

Luka created an automated workflow to process the contract entries and remove the discontinued product references.

For example, imagine a contract contains:

- Basic Job Posting.
- Premium Job Posting.
- Featured Job Boost (discontinued).

The workflow would identify and remove the discontinued product reference while keeping the other products.

These product names are illustrative examples, not actual names from the case study.

Result:

The customer service team reported that the workflow saved the equivalent of two full working days for five full-time employees.

Use case 3: Automating external API data access

Two months of waiting eliminated

Problem:

An internal team needed information from an external API but had spent almost two months trying to obtain access through internal channels.

They depended on engineers and other technical teams to retrieve the required data.

How n8n helped:

Luka demonstrated how the team could use n8n to connect to the external API.

The employees entered their API credentials and retrieved the required information through an n8n workflow.

Result:

- The team accessed the required data almost immediately.
- Dependency on developers was reduced.
- Employees gained more independence in solving their own problems.

5. Overall business impact

The implementation of n8n delivered several benefits to Stepstone.

Area	**Business impact**
Productivity	Reduced repetitive manual work
Time savings	Tasks that took hours or days became much faster
Data processing	Handles 2–3 million job-related documents monthly
Automation growth	More than 700 active workflows
Security	Better access control and separate environments
Employee empowerment	Non-technical employees can learn and use automation
AI integration	Chatbot helps employees identify and design automation opportunities

6. Conclusion

Stepstone's case study demonstrates how automation can transform business operations in a large organization.

The company started using n8n in 2021 with one engineer. As more departments experienced the benefits, automation expanded across the organization.

By upgrading to n8n Enterprise, Stepstone improved security, workflow management and scalability.

It also introduced AI-powered assistance and employee training to make automation accessible to non-technical teams.

The real-world examples demonstrate how n8n helped reduce manual work, save employee time, simplify data processing and reduce dependency on technical teams.

The biggest achievement: Stepstone transformed automation from an activity mainly performed by developers into a capability that employees across the organization can use to solve their everyday business problems.